

ABSTENTION AND INFORMATION-DEFICIENCY DOCTRINE

Document ID: SH-GOV-ABSTAIN-001 | **Version:** 1.0.0 | **Effective:** September 2, 2026 | **State:** LOCKED

Owner: Corporate Governance | **Related:** board intelligence, EIB, decision quality | **Cross-reference:** DECISION_QUALITY_AND_AFTER_ACTION_LEARNING.md; ../j2/EIB_AND_ENTERPRISE_QUESTIONS.md

Permission to say “I don't know”

Abstention is permitted. Sable Harbor would rather preserve honest uncertainty than manufacture confidence for appearance or speed. An abstention is neither silent assent nor automatic opposition.

On a consequential matter, the abstainer records the substantive reason, information believed missing, and what would support a better judgment where reasonably knowable. A conflict-based recusal is recorded separately so it is not mistaken for epistemic abstention.

Abstention as telemetry

Abstention reveals the health of institutional intelligence. Patterns prompt inquiry into:

- inadequate board or management intelligence;
- poor briefing or decision framing;
- insufficient time or inaccessible evidence;
- structural information-routing failure;
- unclear ownership or authority;
- an individual's inability or unwillingness to exercise judgment.

The inquiry seeks the cause rather than punishing the signal. If the system is failing, the system is repaired. If a person persistently refuses to learn, inquire, or exercise the judgment required by office, the issue may eventually become fitness for office.

There is no mechanical three-strikes rule. Frequency alone proves little; subject, consequence, access, effort, and pattern matter. **I don't know is acceptable. Refusing to find out is not.**

Decision record and follow-through

The decision record distinguishes abstention, recusal, dissent, and absence. Material missing information becomes a visible requirement with ownership and disposition where appropriate. Later acquisition of the missing information does not silently rewrite the original vote or state of knowledge.

Controlled publication • Generated from
docs/governance/ABSTENTION_AND_INFORMATION_DEFICIENCY.md • Do not alter PDF manually